

Apps

Essential China Apps: The Complete Guide by Category

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Essential China Apps: The Complete Guide by

Category

Your phone is your everything in China -- payments, transport, food delivery, communication, and more. Here's every app you need, organized by category, with setup tips.

Download Priority (What to Install First):

Alipay + WeChat (with payment setup) -- BEFORE you fly

Amap (高德地图) -- Navigation

DiDi -- Transportation

4 Pleco -- Dictionary/Translation

5 Meituan -- Food delivery

6 Dianping -- Restaurant discovery

7 12306 / Trip.com -- Train tickets

8 Xiaohongshu -- Local tips and hidden gems

Payment Apps (Most Important!)

* Alipay (支付宝)

* -- The #1 payment app in China. Used everywhere: restaurants, shops, taxis, vending machines, even street food stalls. International credit cards (Visa/Mastercard) now supported. Download before arrival and link your card.

* WeChat (微信)

* -- China's "super app" for messaging, payments, mini-programs, and social media.

WeChat Pay is the second most popular payment method. You'll need it to pay, chat, and

access services. Download and set up WeChat Pay with your international card.

Setup tip:

Both Alipay and WeChat now allow international credit card binding. Do this BEFORE you fly to China. Test with a small payment after landing.

Navigation & Maps

* Amap / Gaode (高德地图)

* -- The best navigation app in China. Accurate maps, real-time traffic, public transit routes, and walking directions. Google Maps does NOT work well in China. This is essential.

* Baidu Maps (百度地图)

* -- Alternative to Amap. Good for searching restaurants and businesses. Some prefer its interface.

* Apple Maps

* -- Works okay in China if you're an iPhone user. Uses Amap data underneath. Good enough for basic navigation.

Transport & Travel

* DiDi (滴滴出行)

* -- China's Uber. Book taxis, private cars, and shared rides. Integrated into Alipay and WeChat (no separate app needed). Supports English interface.

* 12306 (铁路12306)

* -- Official train ticket app. Book high-speed rail and regular train tickets. Accepts international credit cards. Book up to 15 days in advance.

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* Trip.com (携程)

* -- Best English-friendly app for booking flights, trains, hotels, and attraction tickets.

Small booking fee but excellent English support.

* Meituan (美团)

* -- Scan and rent shared bikes (Meituan Bike / Mobike). Also for food delivery and local deals.

Food & Delivery

* Meituan (美团)

* -- #1 food delivery app. Order from any restaurant. Also for grocery delivery, hotel booking, and attraction tickets. Chinese only -- use camera translation.

* Ele.me (饿了么)

* -- Second biggest food delivery app. Backed by Alibaba. Similar to Meituan.

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* Dianping (大众点评)

* -- China's Yelp. Restaurant reviews, ratings, photos, and deals. Essential for finding

good restaurants. Search by location, cuisine, or price range.

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* Luckin Coffee (瑞幸咖啡)

* -- China's biggest coffee chain. Order ahead and skip the line. Cheaper than Starbucks.

¥9.9-15 per cup.

Communication & Social

* WeChat (微信)

* -- Already listed under payments, but it's also THE messaging app. Everyone uses it.

Groups, voice messages, video calls, moments (like Facebook). You cannot survive in

China without WeChat.

* Xiaohongshu / RED (小红书)

* -- China's Instagram + Pinterest. Discover restaurants, travel tips, hidden gems, and

lifestyle content. Very popular with young Chinese. Great for finding trendy spots.

* Douyin (抖音)

* -- Chinese TikTok. Different from international TikTok -- more Chinese content, local trends, and useful life hacks.

* Weibo (微博)

* -- China's Twitter. Follow news, celebrities, and trending topics.

Translation & Language

* Pleco

* -- The BEST Chinese dictionary app. Camera translation, handwriting input, and offline dictionary. Free with premium add-ons. Every foreigner in China uses this.

* Apple Translate / Microsoft Translator

* -- Good for offline translation. Download the Chinese language pack before arrival.

* DeepL

* -- Best quality translation for longer texts. Works in China without VPN.

Shopping & Services

* Taobao (淘宝)

* -- China's Amazon. Buy anything from clothes to electronics to furniture. Cheap prices, fast delivery. Use Alipay to pay.

* JD.com (京东)

* -- Premium shopping platform. Better quality control than Taobao. Fast same-day/next-day delivery. Great for electronics and branded goods.

* Pinduoduo (拼多多)

* -- Budget shopping. Group-buy deals for ultra-low prices. Quality varies but great for everyday items.

Entertainment

* Bilibili (B站)

* -- China's YouTube. Anime, gaming, tech reviews, and educational content. Many

videos have Chinese subtitles.

- * iQiyi (爱奇艺)

- * -- China's Netflix. Movies, TV shows, and original content. Some English content available.

- * NetEase Music (网易云音乐)

- * -- Best music app in China. Huge library of Chinese and international music. Great music community and playlists.

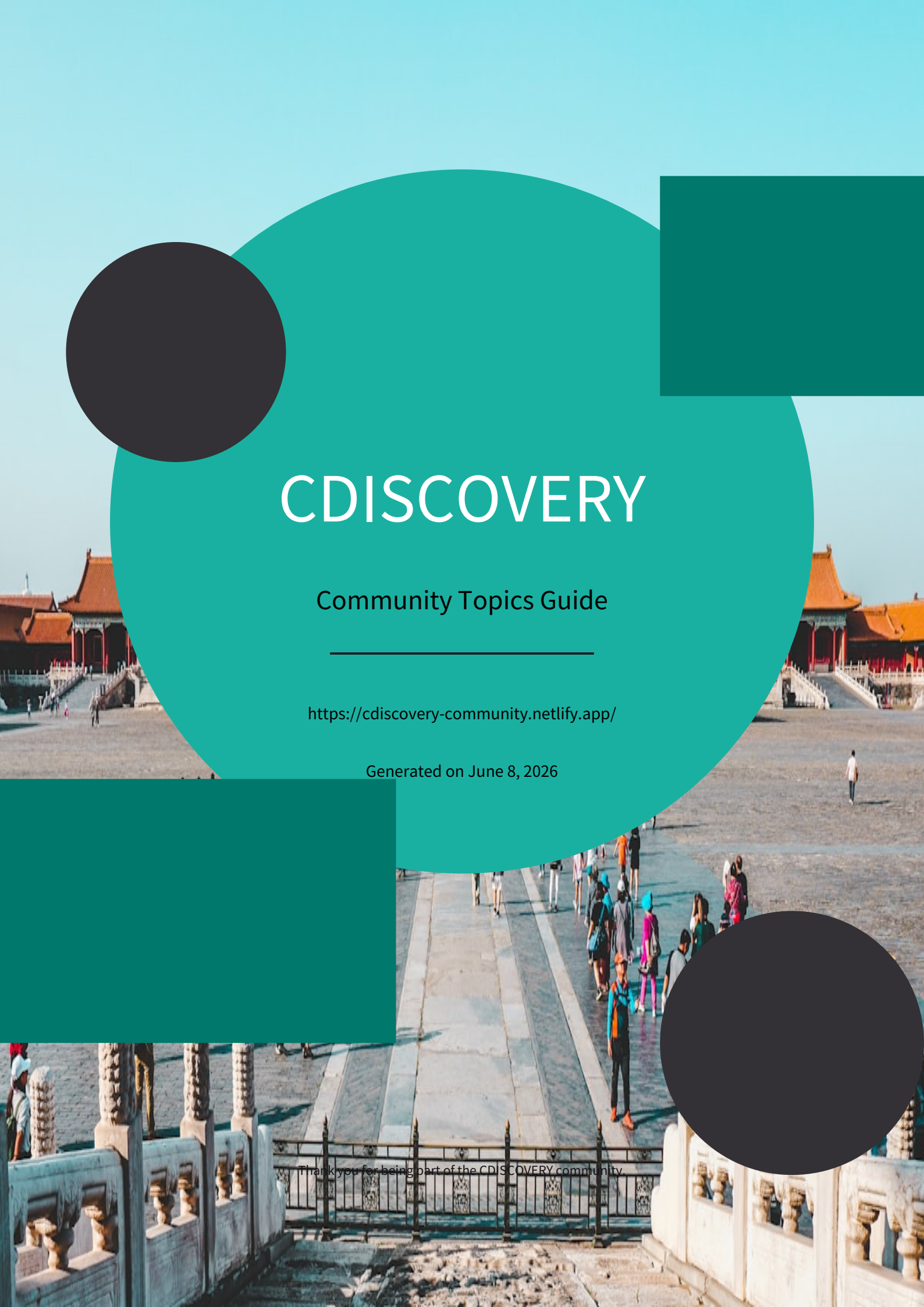
- * Honor of Kings (王者荣耀)

- * -- China's most popular mobile game. Great way to make Chinese friends.

Sources: Sources: Community experiences • [China](https://www.chinahighlights.com)

Highlights

 • [The Beijinger](https://www.thebeijinger.com)



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Community Topics Guide

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